

Polygon vs Finnhub — Market Data Vendor Comparison

MarketCatalyst.ai — feature-by-feature evaluation against the app's actual data requirements

Prepared 2026-07-24 • Internal decision document • Confidential

VERDICT

Neither vendor alone fully satisfies the app's requirement — both leave the Options screen unresolved. For the layer that actually matters — **fundamentals, forward estimates, analyst actions and calendars** — **Finnhub is the better and materially cheaper choice**, confirmed redistributable, at roughly **half of what Polygon currently costs**. Recommended architecture: **keep Polygon for proven live prices/charts, add Finnhub for the estimates/analyst/calendar gap, solve Options separately via Tradier** (already provisioned, free). See § Recommendation for the two items to confirm in writing before signing.

1. Cost comparison

	Polygon (current)	Finnhub (offer)
Core data / month	\$2,000	\$750 (30% off → \$525 for months 1–3)
Economic calendar	Partial via FRED — free	+\$250 / month
Steady-state monthly	\$2,000	\$1,000
Annual (Year 1)	\$24,000	~\$11,325 (intro discount applied)
Annual (Year 2+)	\$24,000	\$12,000

Finnhub is roughly 50% cheaper than the current Polygon spend, while covering strictly more of the app's outstanding requirements (see feature table). Every dollar figure above is as quoted / as invoiced — nothing estimated.

Open flag on the Polygon number: at \$2,000/month, a live API probe of the production key on 2026-07-22 still returned **403 NOT_AUTHORIZED** on options greeks/IV/OI/bid-ask, index spot values (SPX/VIX), and every /benzinga/v1/* endpoint — capabilities normally expected at this price point. Get a written entitlement list from Polygon before any further spend: either the app isn't using access already paid for, or \$2,000/month buys less than expected and a further add-on would be required to match Finnhub.

2. Feature-by-feature, mapped to the app

Each row is an actual screen or delivery-plan requirement in MarketCatalyst.ai, not a generic vendor feature list.

App screen / requirement	Polygon — \$2,000/mo	Finnhub — \$750–1,000/mo	Verdict
Tape · Movers · Heatmap · Watchlist · Portfolio · Search (live prices / OHLC / quotes)	✓ Live & proven in production, 15-min delay	✓ Listed — real-time vs. delayed status unconfirmed	Polygon
Stock Detail (charts, 5-yr history, splits, dividends)	✓ Live & proven	✓ Listed	Polygon (proven)
Options screen (chain, greeks, IV, OI, bid/ask)	✗ 403 on current entitlement; needs Options Advanced add-on (price TBD)	✗ Not offered at all in this proposal	Neither — 3rd vendor needed (Tradier, already held, free)
Earnings hub — actuals (already 100% delivered)	✓ 10 quarters + 8 annual years, live	✓ 20 years historical	Tie — Finnhub deeper
Earnings hub — forward estimates (the one real gap in Earnings hub)	✗ Blocked — needs Polygon's Benzinga add-on, price unconfirmed	✓ Included — 20-yr historical + 5-yr forward EPS/EBITDA/EBIT/Revenue	Finnhub — confirmed price
Analyst screen (per-firm upgrades / downgrades / price targets)	✗ Blocked — needs Benzinga add-on	✓ Included	Finnhub — confirmed price
Earnings + Macro calendars	✗ Thin coverage (FMP, worker-only — not redistributable to users)	✓ Included, dedicated calendar	Finnhub
Economic calendar	Partial, via free FRED feed	✓ Included, +\$250/mo	Depends whether free FRED already suffices
Insider / 13F screen	Not a Polygon product — app already sources this free via SEC EDGAR directly	✓ Included (redundant with existing free source)	No cost difference — already solved at \$0
Commentary / News feed	✓ Live, proven redistributable	✓ Listed — redistribution now confirmed by vendor	Tie, pending real-time/exchange-fee terms
Company profile · sector metrics · peers · dividends	✓ Included	✓ Included	Tie

3. Open items to confirm before signing anything

■ Ticker universe scope

Finnhub's demo access lists only 8 tickers (AAPL, TSLA, WMT, IBM, F, NVDA, MSFT, PFE), and the offer states production access is limited to "those listed in the offer." The app covers 241+ tickers. **Get written confirmation that the production license covers the full US equity universe**, not the demo list — this is a potential dealbreaker if unconfirmed.

■ Real-time vs. delayed data + exchange display fees

Websockets are listed without a delay/real-time label. If real-time, exchanges (Nasdaq/NYSE/CTA) often charge separate, per-user display fees on top of the vendor price — not necessarily included in the quoted \$750–1,000/month. Ask explicitly and get it in writing.

■ Polygon's actual \$2,000/mo entitlement

A live probe of the production key still 403's on options greeks, index values, and Benzinga endpoints. Request a written entitlement list from Polygon — you may be paying for access the app isn't using, or the plan may need a further paid add-on to match what Finnhub already includes.

■ Options remains unsolved either way

Neither vendor in this comparison provides greeks/IV/OI/bid-ask. Plan for a third source regardless of which of these two is chosen — Tradier (token already provisioned, free with a brokerage account) is the fastest unblock; Polygon Options Advanced is the single-vendor alternative, price still unconfirmed.

4. Recommendation

1. Request Polygon's written entitlement list for the \$2,000/mo plan, and a quoted price for the Benzinga add-on — compare that number directly against Finnhub's \$12,000/yr steady-state.
2. Send Finnhub the two open questions above (ticker-universe scope, real-time/exchange-fee terms) and get answers in writing.
3. If Polygon's real entitlement / add-on cost is not competitive with Finnhub's confirmed \$1,000/mo for the same fundamentals/estimates/analyst/calendar scope, adopt the hybrid architecture: **Polygon stays for live prices & charts (proven, in production) — Finnhub is added for estimates, analyst actions, and calendars (closes R29 / R41 / R42 / R47) — Options is solved separately via Tradier**, independent of this decision.
4. Do not cancel or reduce Polygon until the hybrid path is fully wired and verified — it remains the proven, redistribution-licensed source for every live price/chart screen in the app today.

Sources: live entitlement probes against the production Polygon key (2026-07-22, documented in DELIVERY-PLAN-STATUS.md / 05_API_Vendor_Tracker.md), the Finnhub commercial offer email, and the app's delivery-plan requirement rows R29 / R32 / R41 / R42 / R43 / R47.